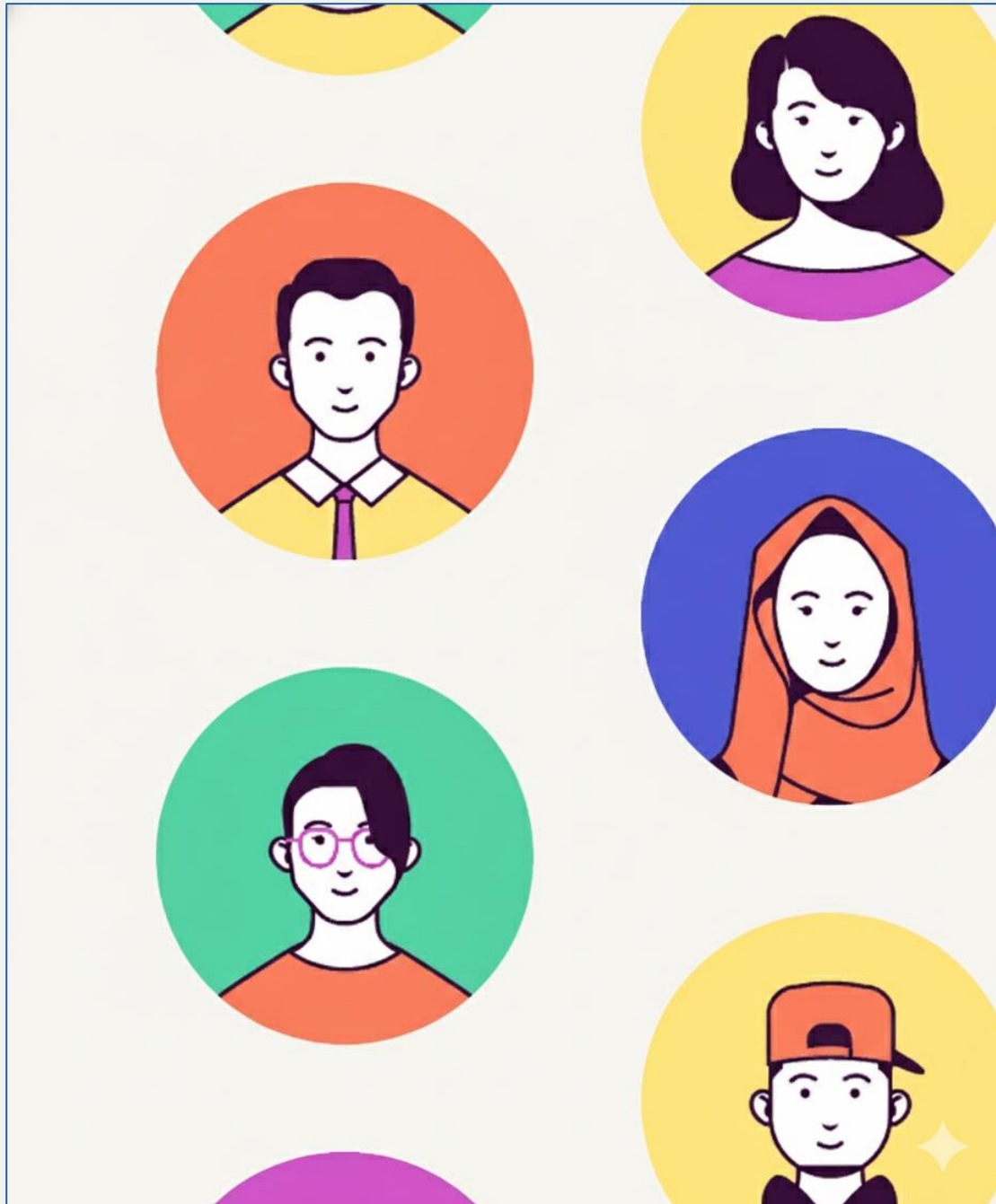




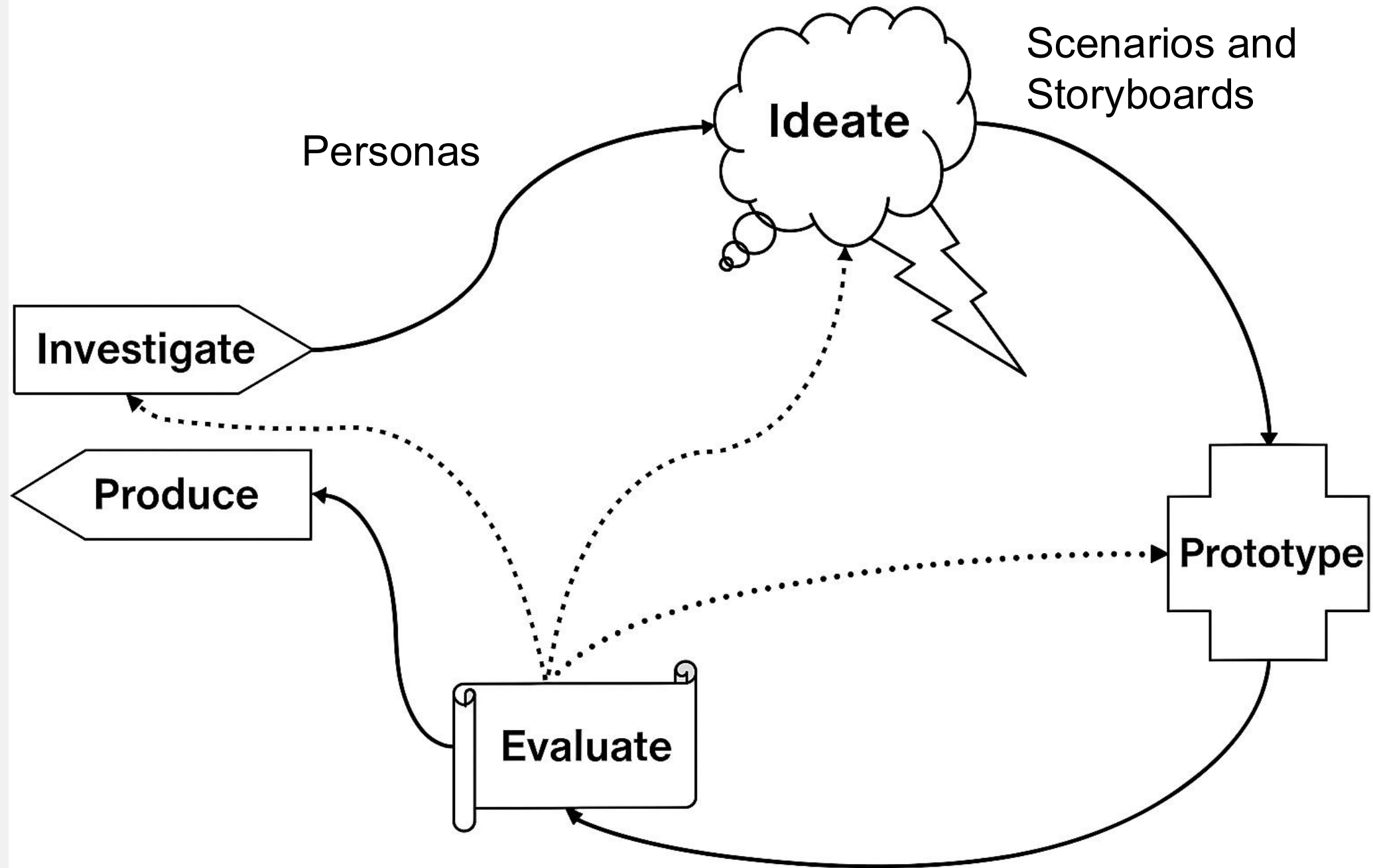
CSE472: HCI – Human Computer Interaction

Lecture – 7: Persona
Spring 2026



Inspiring Excellence

Source: <https://www.wowmakers.com/blog/user-persona/>



What are personas?

- A persona is a fictional character that is meant to represent a group of users that share common goals, attitudes and behaviors when interacting with a particular product or service.



AI generated

Vs.



Source: <https://edenmulticarehospital.com/>

Personas as a design strategy

- Allows you to focus on the specific needs and goals of specific, archetype individual based on user research. The archetype should be specific and precise so that it can be used to make decisions with regard to scope and design.
- *NOT a real person*, but a composite archetype ("typical" user) each persona represents a group of users
- Designing for such an archetype allows us to do really well at making this person happy. Often, it results in something that ends up working well for others, too.

Why develop personas?

- Empathy
 - We are engaged by fictional characters all the time in movies and books.
- Focus: Personas provide a precise way of thinking about...
 - how users behave
 - their motivations
 - how they think
 - what they wish to accomplish (goals)
 - why they want to do what they do
- Communication
 - Provides a way of conveying a broad range of quantitative and qualitative data
 - Assumptions about users made explicit

Why develop personas?

- Within the design/engineering team:
 - provides a shared understanding
 - engage in empathy of design towards a target user
 - helps communicate who you are building the product for
 - helps determine what the product should and shouldn't do
 - serves as a stable reference point during the design process
 - provides focus
 - a stand-in for actual users
 - testable via walkthroughs

Example

SOCIALLY COMPETITIVE SAMANTHA



Name Samantha
Gender Female
Age 28
Education Bachelor's degree
Occupation Marketing; \$75K
Marital Status Single
Location Boston, MA



"I love outsmarting friends in a game, but if it comes down to it, I'll spend money to win."

Motivations

Samantha plays mobile games to pass time and compete against friends, but not necessarily at the same time. When passing short periods of time (e.g., waiting in line), Samantha plays games where she competes against herself. In these scenarios, she opts for low time commitment games where she uses strategy to advance. When passing longer periods of time (e.g., work commute), Samantha plays games where she competes against friends.

Samantha's favorite game is *Bejeweled*. Samantha enjoys the feeling of winning against her real-world friends and goes to great lengths to maintain her dominance, including: frequently purchasing coins. The only other in-app purchases Samantha makes are to unlock levels when she's playing good single-player games like *Spongebob's Dinner Rush*.

Samantha primarily downloads games that are recommended/currently played by friends.

Criteria for Selecting Games

- Free to download and play
- Ability to compete against friends
- Strategic thinking needed, but not a time sink (easy to play, advance and pick back up)

Frustrations with Games

- Cost to download
- Too hard to advance
- When friends become unresponsive

In Samantha's Words

"I get so competitive when I play *Bejeweled* against my friends at work. I spend way too much money just so I can win. Of course, I don't tell my friends I spend anything. I like them thinking I'm naturally gifted."

"*Spongebob's Dinner Rush* is super addictive. When I have few minutes to kill, like waiting in line for coffee in the morning, I try to beat a couple of levels."

Personas are NOT stereotypes

- In a void of user research, designers have only their assumptions and intuitions
- Base your personas on REAL DATA, not assumptions
- *“the whole point in creating personas is to get past our personal opinions and presuppositions.”* Goodwin, 2002
- Thus, make sure your personas do not fall into your stereotypes of people in your target user groups!

Personas are NOT Roles

- Personas do not necessarily have equal roles
 - e.g., parent, doctor, programmer, actor, etc.
- People within the same roles can have very different needs and goals
 - e.g., new vs. experienced programmer
 - e.g., parent of 1 vs. parent of 8
 - e.g., oncologist vs. pediatrician

Different types of personas

- Primary
- Secondary
- Supplemental
- Customer
- Negative

Design Example:
Designing a video
game for kids!

- Make sure you specify the type on your personas!

Primary Persona

Who they are:

The *main user* – the child who will actually play the game.

Description:

Name: Emma, 8 years old

Goals: Wants to have fun, explore new worlds, and feel a sense of achievement.

Behaviors: Plays on a tablet after school, enjoys colorful characters and simple challenges.

Needs: Easy controls, clear instructions, short levels, and positive feedback.

Design focus:

Everything – visuals, controls, gameplay, rewards – is primarily designed for *Emma's* experience.

Secondary Persona

Who they are:

Users who interact with the game *indirectly* or *less frequently*.

Description:

Name: Leo, 10 years old (older brother)

Goals: Might help Emma when she gets stuck or sometimes plays the game too.

Behaviors: Likes more challenging features or multiplayer modes.

Needs: Optional advanced levels or “helper” mode to keep him engaged.

Design focus:

Include optional challenges or cooperative play so older siblings can enjoy it too – without making the main gameplay too hard for younger kids.

Supplemental Persona

Who they are:

People who don't play the game but *interact with it or influence how it's used*.

Description:

Name: Ms. Lopez, a 3rd-grade teacher.

Goals: Wants to use the game as a fun way to reinforce math or reading lessons.

Behaviors: Looks for progress tracking, educational value, and classroom compatibility.

Needs: Teacher dashboard, lesson integration, and safe content.

Design focus:

Include educational alignment and progress reports to make the game useful beyond home entertainment.

Customer Persona

Who they are:

The *buyer* – usually a parent or guardian.

Description:

Name: Sarah, 35, mother of two.

Goals: Wants her kids to have fun while learning something valuable.

Behaviors: Reads reviews, looks for parental controls, and avoids in-app purchases.

Needs: Safe, ad-free experience; good value for money; and reassurance that the game is age-appropriate.

Design focus:

Highlight educational benefits, safety, and parental control features in marketing and product design.

Negative Persona

Who they are:

People *you are not designing for* – they wouldn't find value or might misuse the game.

Description:

Name: Jake, 17 years old, a hardcore gamer.

Goals: Wants high-end graphics, online competition, and complex storylines.

Behaviors: Prefers action or strategy games.

Needs: Advanced gameplay, customization, mature themes.

Design focus:

Don't waste time adding competitive online modes, intense graphics, or violent content – this isn't the audience.

Basic steps to create personas

- 1) Collect data about users  Done
- 2) Segment the users
- 3) Create personas

Segment the users

- Logical groupings of users
- Group users that have similar characteristics, motivations, goals, capabilities, experiences, lives, etc.
- Each group represents one “persona”

Design Example:
Designing a video
game for kids!

PRIMARY  Goals • Have fun • Explore new worlds • Feel a sense of achievement Frustrations • Complicated or confusing gameplay Design Implications • Easy controls, clear instructions • Short levels, positive feedback	SECONDARY  Goals ... • Enjoy more challenging features or play the game too Frustrations • Playing without challenges or getting bored Design Implications • Teacher dashboard • Lesson integration • Safe content
CUSTOMER  Goals • Want her kids to have fun while learning something valuable Sarah 35, mother of two Design Implications • Safe, ad-free	NEGATIVE  Goals • Want high-end graphics • Online competition • Complex Jake 17, hardcore gamer Frustrations • Prefer action or strategy games

Segment the users

THE CASUAL USER



Pete

Uses most phone features

Use phone to make call, use contacts, send texts and take pictures

Always has mobile device with him

THE BUSINESS USER



Jennifer

Wants a simple phone, But functions as one integrated device

Wants to easily read emails and call back the sender

Needs "Popular" mail Server integration

THE POWER USER



Brad

Will use almost all built-in mobile functionality

Will extend phone functionality with additional software

Will look through and change every menu option

Segment the users

Each persona should each have three to four goals

(1) Life goals, which are personal aspirations

- e.g., wanting to retire before the age of 50

(2) Experience goals describe how the user wants to feel while interacting with a product; they are personal and universal

- e.g., wanting to be competent while using the product

(3) End goals, which are tangible outcomes the user has in mind when using the product

- e.g., want to be updated about finances over last month
- Typically experience/end goals are more helpful to designers

Create the persona

- Photo
- **Name** – first name starts with the first letter of the segmentation (e.g., Garrett the gamer, Peter the parent)
- **Quote** that describes the user goals with the product
- **Goals** - a priority rating and specific objectives are also suggested
- **Biographical profile and personal information** that affects usage
- **Computer, internet and other technology usage** are common components
- **Key Point:** Back up persona with data whenever possible!

Some Examples

Phone upgrades

Toby – “Fashion Phone Upgrader”



“One year in phones is a long time”

Toby loves technology and has to be seen with the newest and coolest digital gadgets. His phone is not just about making calls; he loves using its wealth of features for everything he can: surfing the web, writing emails, social networking and using it as a personal organiser.

Because he gets bored quickly with his phones, Toby is always looking for the latest toy and pays attention to new releases. He frequently upgrades part way through his contract and is willing to pay the upgrade fee to get the best phone. To him, a contract is a mere inconvenience, but something he endures to get a bigger discount off his new phone

Behaviours



Key Characteristics

- Age 20-35
- Is tech savvy
- Loves showing off his new phone to friends
- Would find a way to get out of his current contract for the latest phone
- Keeps up to date with the latest phones online
- Gets bored with phones quickly

Goals

- Have the latest, coolest phone
- Be up to date with the newest phones on the market
- Use as many features on his phone as possible

Phone upgrades

Shen – “The follower”



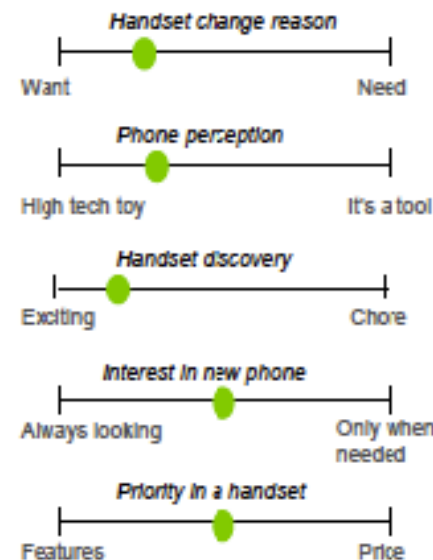
“I never get ‘the’ phone, I’m always one or two steps behind”

Shen uses his phone primarily to keep in contact with his family and enjoys using it to take photos of his children. Although he would like to own a smart phone so he can use it for emails and the internet, they are currently too expensive for his budget

Shen tries to keep his phone until he’s eligible for a discounted upgrade, although, if given the option, he would upgrade more often for the novelty of having a new phone.

Constantly surprised at how quickly technology is changing, he is always interested to see new the newest phones on the market.

Behaviours



Key Characteristics

- Age 35-45
- Shops around before renewing his phone
- Is price conscious; thinks twice before buying
- Is tempted by new phones
- Would consider upgrading if a life event called for a new phone
- Needs a good reason to spend money on a phone e.g. more megapixels on a camera
- Does not want to be embarrassed to pull out his phone in public

Goals

- Get to the end of his contract so that he can get a cheaper upgrade
- Get the best deal that he can, taking into account the rate plan and the handset
- Purchase a high-end phone when he can justify the extra cost

Some templates for you...

- Google image search has millions of examples/templates....
- <https://www.justinmind.com/blog/user-persona-templates/>

<Persona name>



“Insert quote that characterises this persona in one sentence.”

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat. Duis aute irure dolor in reprehenderit in voluptate velit esse cillum dolore eu fugiat nulla pariatur.

Name <name>
Type <type>
Role <role>

Motivations

- Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non.
- Sunt in culpa qui officia deserunt mollit anim id est laborum.
- Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non.

Goals

- Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non.
- Sunt in culpa qui officia deserunt mollit anim id est laborum.
- Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non.

Pain points

- Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non.
- Sunt in culpa qui officia deserunt mollit anim id est laborum.
- Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non.

Behaviours

Variable description



Variable description



Variable description



Variable description



Variable description



Variable description



PERSONA PROFILE



INTERESTS:

What does she spend her time on?
What enlivens her?
What does she read, watch, ?
listen to?

POWERS:

What Resources does she control?
What can she do, muster?
Who does she have influence over?

Name:

Fictionalize it

Profession:

Be very specific

Age:

Choose a number,
Not a Range

Personal

Bg:

Mini Life story -
Hometown, Family,
Schooling, Work, etc

NEEDS:

What does she need,
in her life, in her work?
What's essential for her,
what does she require?
What's missing?

BEHAVIORS:

What are her
ROUTINES
BUYING
Free Time
Rituals

VALUES:

What carries meaning for her?
What's her moral compass?
What makes her indignant,
satisfied, frustrated?
What does she want for the world?

ASPIRATIONS:

What kind of person
do they want to be?
Brands?
Spending patterns?
Life Dreams? Heroes?
Role Models?

Summary of Personas

- Personas are fictional characters
- Based on user research
- Represent different user types that might use your service, product or site in similar ways
- Helps you to understand your users' needs, experiences, behaviors and goals.
- Recognize that different people have different needs and expectations. Help you to identify with the user you're designing for.
- Help you to achieve the goal of creating a good user experience for your target user group

Any questions?